

Chapter 16

The Secret She Never Told

The next morning...

Roman sat alone in his office.

The city moved quietly beyond the glass walls.

But his attention was fixed on the laptop in front of him.

Noah's phone recovery was finally complete enough to reveal something.

Not everything.

Some files were corrupted.

Some messages were incomplete.

But what Roman was seeing was enough to change the direction of the investigation.

His investigator stood beside the desk.

"We recovered several conversations."

Roman looked up.

"Between Noah and Ethan?"

"Yes."

"Show me."

The investigator opened the first folder.

Photos appeared on the screen.

Some were damaged.

Others were clear enough.

Noah and Ethan.

Together.

Not like ordinary friends.

Roman stared at the screen.

He opened another file.

Then another.

The same pattern appeared again.

Private messages.

Pictures.

Conversations that made one thing clear.

Roman leaned back slowly.

"So they were together."

"Yes, sir."

Roman said nothing.

His mind immediately went to Elara.

Noah had been her best friend.

How had Elara never known?

The investigator opened another recovered conversation.

Noah:

I still can't believe I'm actually going to tell everyone.

Ethan:

Are you sure?

Noah:

Yes.

Ethan:

Maybe wait.

Noah:

I've waited long enough.

Another message appeared.

Noah:

I'm going to tell Elara first.

Roman's eyes narrowed.

Then another message.

Noah:

My birthday is the perfect time.

Roman stared at the screen.

The investigator looked at him.

"She was planning to surprise them."

Roman nodded slowly.

"Elara had no idea."

"No."

Roman leaned closer to the screen.

Another message appeared.

Noah:

She'll be so happy.

Roman's expression softened for a moment.

Then another message appeared.

Noah:

I just hope Ethan doesn't change his mind.

Roman's eyes hardened.

He read it again.

Something about that sentence bothered him.

"Recover everything connected to Ethan."

"Already doing it."

"And don't tell Elara yet."

The investigator nodded.

Roman closed the laptop.

He wasn't going to tell Elara about the relationship until he understood what had happened after those messages.

Because a relationship was not proof of murder.

It was only another piece of the puzzle.

Across the city...

Elara sat at her desk.

She tried to concentrate on work.

But she couldn't.

Roman's recent behavior kept bothering her.

He was hiding something.

She could feel it.

She picked up her phone.

Opened his contact.

Typed:

Did you find something?

She stared at it.

Then deleted it.

She tried again.

Are you hiding something from me?

Delete.

She sighed and put the phone down.

Then suddenly...

something flashed through her mind.

A room.

A quiet hallway.

Roman standing in front of her.
Not angry.
Not distant.
Just...
nervous.
Elara froze.
She closed her eyes.
The memory disappeared.
She opened them again.
Her heart was beating faster.
"What was that?"
She tried to remember.
Nothing.
Only Roman's face.
And a strange feeling she couldn't explain.
She whispered,
"You said something to me that night..."
But what?
She pressed her fingers against her forehead.
Another tiny fragment appeared.
Roman's voice.
Soft.
Almost uncertain.
"Elara..."
Her eyes opened.
She looked around the empty office.
For a moment...
she could almost hear him.
Then the memory disappeared again.

That evening...
Roman stood alone in his apartment.
The recovered files were open on his laptop.
He looked through Noah's messages one more time.

The last message before the conversation ended was:

Noah:

Tomorrow. I'll tell Elara everything.

Roman looked at the date.

His expression changed.

Tomorrow was the day Noah died.

He slowly closed the laptop.

Something had happened between that message...

and the library.

Something important.

Something that had never been recorded.

That night...

Elara sat beside her bedroom window.

The city lights were blurred beneath the dark sky.

She picked up her phone.

Roman's name appeared on the screen.

She didn't call him.

She simply stared at it.

Then...

another memory came.

Roman standing in front of her.

His eyes looking directly into hers.

His voice was gentle.

"I need to tell you something."

Elara's breathing stopped.

The memory vanished before she could see anything else.

She opened her eyes.

Her heart was pounding.

She whispered,

"What did you tell me?"

She didn't know yet.

But somewhere inside her mind...

a door that had been locked for a long time had finally begun to open.

And behind that door...

was the answer to something she had forgotten.